

A-LEVEL BUSINESS · AQA 7137 AND 7138 · SECTION 3.1.1

SMART Objectives: Accountable, Not Achievable

In AQA 7138 the A does not stand for Achievable. One page for you, one page for your class.

WHAT THE SPECIFICATION PRINTS

“characteristics of effective objectives: Specific, Measurable, Accountable, Realistic, Time specific (SMART)”

AQA AS and A-level Business 7137, 7138 specification, Version 1.1, November 2025, section 3.1.1, page 12.

S

Specific

M

Measurable

A

Accountable

R

Realistic

T

Time specific

AQA's five words, in AQA's own order and spelling. Some textbooks use a different version of the A.

Why your textbook says Achievable

Other SMART frameworks commonly use Achievable or Attainable. Those versions are widely used and they are not errors. They are a different version of the same mnemonic. AQA 7138 uses Accountable, and an answer written for AQA 7138 should use Accountable.

SAY THIS TO THE CLASS

“For AQA 7138 the A stands for Accountable. Other SMART frameworks use Achievable or Attainable. That is a different version, not a mistake. In your AQA answers, use Accountable.”

OUR VIEW: THIS BIT IS TBS, NOT AQA

AQA prints the word Accountable without defining it. We teach it as “the objective has a named owner”, because that is what makes it usable in a classroom and in a case study. Treat that as a working rule of ours, not as an AQA definition, and do not give it to students as one.

AQA 7138 · SECTION 3.1.1 · BUSINESS OBJECTIVES

Which letter is missing?

Specific · Measurable · Accountable · Realistic · Time specific

Milton Row Cycles is a two-person bike workshop. It services about 60 bikes a month, and a repair currently takes about five working days. The workshop has confirmed capacity for up to 80 bikes per month without additional staff. Yusuf owns the shop; Beth is the workshop lead. (Fictional business.)

Task A: for each objective, name the letter or letters it is missing. Task B: rewrite objective 1 so that it meets all five.

1 “We want Milton Row Cycles to do better next year.”

Missing: _____

2 “Increase the number of bikes serviced each month from 60 to 75 by 31 December, measured from the workshop booking log.”

Missing: _____

3 “Service 600 bikes a month by 31 December, tracked on the booking log every Friday by Beth, the workshop lead.”

Missing: _____

Task B: your rewrite of objective 1:

TEACHER: FULL ANSWERS

- 1 It does not demonstrate any of the five: Specific, Measurable, Accountable, Realistic or Time specific. Because the intended change is undefined, realism cannot be assessed.
- 2 Missing Accountable only. It is specific (bikes serviced), measurable (60 to 75), realistic against the confirmed capacity of 80 a month, and time specific (31 December). Nobody is named, so nobody owns it. This would pass versions that use Achievable, but it fails AQA 7138 because no one is accountable.
- 3 Missing Realistic only. It is specific, measurable, accountable (Beth is named) and time specific, but 600 a month is ten times what the workshop currently services and well beyond its stated capacity.

Task B: model rewrite of objective 1

“Increase the number of bikes serviced each month from 60 to 70 by 31 December, measured in the booking log every Friday and owned by Beth, the workshop lead.”

Accept any objective with a named outcome, a number, a date, a named owner and a scale within the workshop's 80 a month capacity. Check Realistic against the case data; for AQA 7138, remember that the A is Accountable.